Let it be only a *kare* leaf,
If it come from dedicated work,
Is worthy to be offered to Linga . . .
For, as work is worship,
God is present in the work which we perform.[11]

Simple though it was, the philosophy of the lingayats clashed dangerously with the political realities of twelfth-century India.

Like the Buddhist monasteries of Sri Lanka, the Hindu temples of central India were supported by royal grants of cash and tax-free farmland. The Brahman priests who served in them accepted the king's money and land; in return, they supported the king's policies. They held themselves apart in their own caste, marrying within their own kind and keeping their priestly lands inside their own class. But the Brahmans were powerful not only through wealth but also through the temple service itself. They presided over a system of Hindu worship that was complicated and inflexible, and yet was the only way to reach the divine presence. Without Brahman guidance, the Hindu worshipper was lost.[12]

But the philosophy of Basava and the other lingayats did away with the Brahmans. For them, each worshipper came to Shiva alone, on his own terms, in a personal encounter that was inward and mysterious and needed no temples, no sacrifices, and no Brahmans. The only service Shiva required was dedicated manual labor—the very activity that Brahmans, by law, were to shun. Even more worrying, lingayatism did away with all sorts of other barriers and divisions within Hindu society. Women and men were equally welcome. In the worship of Shiva, there was no class privilege or shame. The lowest ranks of Indian society—those who worked with their hands—were honored rather than shunned. Lingayatism spread rapidly through Bijjala's kingdom; and it threatened both the Brahman monopoly and the royal authority that the Brahmans spent their lives shoring up.[13]

Basava short-circuited his own success by getting reckless with the king's treasury. He spent a good deal of Bijjala's money on feeding, supporting, and entertaining his fellow lingayats. Around 1167, Bijjala II became aware of the theft. He retaliated by blinding two of the most prominent lingayats, an indirect and unproductive punishment that ultimately killed both the king and his minister. There are at least four different versions of what happened next, but it seems that Bijjala was assassinated by one (or more) indignant lingayats; Basava fled, but Bijjala's son and successor, Someshvara, sent